

5 MILLION

THE ESTIMATED NUMBER OF PEOPLE WHO DIED IN THE RUSSIAN FAMINE OF 1921



Russian famine victims receive food from a relief train. The US played a leading role in the international effort to feed the starving.

refused to ratify it. Representatives of 41 countries attended the League's first General Assembly in Geneva in November, but neither Germany nor Russia was among them.

Meanwhile, **war had broken out in Ireland**, where Britain was resisting the declaration of an Irish Republic. British World War I veterans were recruited into two new units, the Black and Tans and the Auxiliaries, to fight the Irish Republican Army (IRA). On November 21, in an operation planned by IRA intelligence chief **Michael Collins** (1890–1922), the IRA killed 13 people in Dublin. The Auxiliaries responded the same afternoon by firing into a Gaelic soccer crowd, killing 14 people.

In the same month, on the second anniversary of the armistice ending World War I, Britain and France each **buried an Unknown Soldier**. The French soldier was entombed at the Arc de Triomphe in Paris, and the British soldier in Westminster Abbey in London. It was intended to commemorate all those who had given their lives, irrespective of rank or social class.

The last major event of the year was the accession of **General Alvaro Obregón** (1880–1928) as president of **Mexico**. Obregón had been one of the chief players in the civil conflicts that had torn the country apart since the Mexican Revolution (see 1910). His armed overthrow of President Venustiano Carranza (1859–1920) gave Obregón the chance to establish a relatively stable government.

IN 1921, RUSSIA experienced one of the most **destructive famines** of the 20th century. Years of warfare and revolution had laid waste to the Russian countryside, which was further devastated by drought in the Volga region. As hundreds of thousands died of starvation and disease, Lenin's Bolshevik government reluctantly appealed for foreign relief. The most prominent participant in the **international humanitarian effort** was the American Relief Administration, led by future US president Herbert Hoover (1874–1964). Despite the distribution of food aid to around 10 million people, millions died by the time the famine abated the following year.

The **Bolsheviks** continued to impose the will of their party upon their devastated country. In March, workers, soldiers, and sailors rebelled at the naval

fortress of Kronstadt, demanding free elections, freedom of speech, and the right of peasants to own land and cattle. The **rebellion** was crushed by Bolshevik forces, but faced with popular discontent and economic devastation, the Bolsheviks had to retreat from some of the communist measures they had adopted. **Lenin's New Economic Policy** (NEP) allowed a limited capitalist market economy. Once peasants were permitted to sell their produce at a profit, the rural economy quickly recovered and food supplies were assured.

Despite the tribulations of the Russian Bolshevik government, its example continued to stimulate the foundation of Communist parties across the world. This included the **Communist Party of China**, which held its founding congress in Shanghai in July.

In Ireland, Britain attempted to fulfill its pre-World War I commitment to **Irish Home Rule** (see 1914). To appease the Irish Protestants the country was divided. Home Rule parliaments were established in Dublin and Belfast, and both parts remained within the United Kingdom. This was accepted by the Protestants, but rejected by Irish Republicans. **Negotiations** opened in London, and on December 6 the Irish delegation agreed to accept the **division of Ireland** in return for Dominion status within the British Commonwealth. Southern Ireland became the **Irish Free State**, but many Irish Republicans were outraged by the compromises



Division of Ireland
Northern Ireland, with a mainly Protestant population, was separated from southern Ireland, which became the Irish Free State.

MAO ZEDONG (1893–1976)

The son of a farmer, Mao helped to found the Chinese Communist Party in 1921. He developed the idea of basing a revolution on support from peasants, rather than industrial workers. From 1949 he ruled Communist China as party chairman. His radical policies, including the Great Leap Forward in 1958 and the Cultural Revolution of the 1960s, caused vast disruption and loss of life.



in the Anglo-Irish Treaty, which led to civil war (see 1922).

Britain also had **troubles at home**. A brief post-war economic boom was followed by the collapse in demand for products from many of the country's traditional industries, such as coal mining and shipbuilding. By June, more than **2 million people were unemployed**. For the men who had fought in World War I, it was a bitter irony to find themselves lining up for unemployment benefits.

In the US, racism and anxieties about political subversion were rife. In **Tulsa, Oklahoma**, the most destructive **race riot** in American history saw most of the African-American section of the town destroyed in white attacks. Support for the white supremacist Ku Klux Klan rose rapidly, and concerns about the racial makeup of the US population

were reflected in tight limits on foreign immigration. **The Emergency Quota Act** linked the right of entry to country of origin, blocking mass immigration from southern and eastern Europe. Asians were entirely excluded.

The assumption of white racial superiority suffered a severe blow in **Morocco**, which the **French and Spanish** had casually divided into "spheres of influence." Spanish troops attempting to control the mountainous Rif region were surrounded and massacred by local **Berbers** at the Battle of Annual in July. The Berber leader Abd el-Krim declared the region an **independent Rif republic**, but it succumbed to a combined French and Spanish counter-attack four years later.

December 22 Congress of Soviets adopts ambitious plan for electrification in Russia

December 30 French Communist Party founded at Tours congress

December 23 Government of Ireland Act creates separate parliaments for northern and southern Ireland

February 9 Indian parliament opens in Delhi

February 25 Russian Red Army enters Tbilisi in Georgia

May 5 Inter-Allied Reparations Commission sets total German payments at 132 billion Deutsche Marks

May 19 Emergency Quota Act severely restricts immigration to US

June 7 Northern Ireland parliament opens

July 14 In Massachusetts, Italian anarchists **Sacco and Vanzetti** found guilty of murder

August 26 German moderate politician **Matthias Erzberger** assassinated by nationalist extremists

September 18 Berber nationalist Abd el-Krim founds Rif Republic

December 6 Anglo-Irish Treaty signed in London, ending Irish independence war

March 21 Lenin introduces New Economic Policy, allowing limited free market activity in Russia

May 31 Over 80 deaths and large-scale destruction of property during race riot in **Tulsa, Oklahoma**

July 1 Communist Party of China founded

July 22 Rebels in Rif region of Spanish Morocco inflict humiliating defeat on Spanish troops at Annual

August 23 Faisal I becomes king of Iraq, under close British supervision

September 13 At Battle of Salamiya, Turkish nationalists block Greek army advancing on Ankara

November 9 Fascist Party founded in Italy

December 29 Mackenzie King becomes prime minister of Canada, a post he holds for 21 of the following 27 years